



Cambridge (CIE) IGCSE English Language



Your notes

Question 1: Comprehension

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Your notes

How to Answer Question 1: Comprehension

How to Answer Question 1: Comprehension

Paper 1: Reading is the compulsory exam in the CIE IGCSE, and CIE examiners recommend that you complete the questions in the order they are set. Question 1 is split into two tasks: a comprehension task and a summary task. The comprehension task will be based on **Text A** in your reading insert.

The following guide will provide you with the information you need to answer **Question 1: Comprehension** confidently.

Overview for Question 1

For this task, you will respond to a series of sub-questions about Text A. These sub-questions will test your understanding of both explicit and implicit meanings, and your ability to select and use information from the text (Assessment Objectives R1, R2 and R5). The sub-questions are worth 15 marks in total and are broken down as follows:

Question	What you are asked to do	Marks
1(a)	Identify two specific pieces of information from the text	1
1(b)(i)	Explain, <i>using your own words</i> , what a word or phrase in the text means	2
	The word or phrase will have a surface meaning for you to explain	
1(b)(ii)	Explain, <i>using your own words</i> , what a word or phrase means	2
	The word or phrase will have a more implicit meaning, which means you will have to consider its meaning a little more carefully	
1(c)	Identify two specific pieces of information from the text	2
1(d)(i)	Identify two specific pieces of information from the text	2
1(d)(ii)	Explain something, making three separate points, based on the text	3
1(e)	Explain something from the text <i>using your own words</i> , making three separate points	3

Use inference here to find the suggested or hidden meaning



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Breaking down the questions

Question 1: Comprehension will be divided into seven sub-questions. It is important that you read each question carefully and highlight:

- The command words in each question (what you have to do)
- The focus of each question (what you are looking for in the text)
- How many marks each question is worth (this indicates how much you need to write)

Question 1 example:

Read **Text A, *Endurance events***, in the insert and then answer **Questions 1(a)–(e)** on this question paper.

Question 1

(a) Give the **two** examples of types of endurance events, other than ultra-marathons, according to the text.

.....

..... [1]

(b) (i) **Using your own words**, explain what the text means by:

'challenge the limits' (line 3):

.....

..... [2]

(ii) **Using your own words**, explain what the text means by:

'mythical beast' (line 4):

.....

..... [2]

Here are the marks. There are 2 marks for this question, so you have to make sure you have explained the whole of the phrase

This reminds you which text you are working from

These are your instructions: in this case, you need to give two examples

This is the focus of the question – it tells you what to look for in the text

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Steps to success

Following these steps will give you a strategy for answering this question effectively:

1. Read the question and **highlight**:

1. The command words (what you are instructed to do)
2. The focus of the question (the words or phrases you have to look for in the text)
3. When highlighting, take note of the marks given for each sub-question

2. Scan Text A and highlight the evidence that answers the question, or the words or phrases you need to explain:

1. Remember that there may be more than one answer - make sure your answer provides what the question instructions have asked for

3. Write your answers according to the question instructions:

1. If the question asks for two examples, then make sure you give two separate examples
2. If the question asks you to use your own words, then make sure you do not repeat words from the text
3. Check how many marks are awarded for each question, and tailor your answers accordingly
4. When explaining the meaning of a phrase, consider the context of the text (do not just guess the meaning without context)
5. Remember, not all of the answers will be explicit:
 1. You will have to make some inferences or read between the lines

You are advised to spend no more than 15–20 minutes on this question (including reading time).

Exam tips

- Read the command words and the paragraph references in the instructions carefully
- Do not write overly long explanations or answers in your own words where they are not required:
 - Equally, make sure you do not just repeat the language of the text in answers where your own words are required
 - It is made clear in the task instructions when you should write your answers using your own words
- Avoid adding additional unnecessary material and/or extra guesses in your answers
- Follow the order of the sub-questions and work through the text from the beginning
- Where a question asks you to explain a phrase in your own words, make sure you explain the meaning of the whole of the phrase (rather than just trying to analyse an individual word in the phrase)



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- Where a question directs you to a particular paragraph(s), make sure that you only use the sections of text specified:

- You will not be awarded marks for anything taken outside of these sections or paragraphs

The full June 2022 exam paper is available [here](#).

For more advice on how to apply the skills required for success in this question, please see our [Question 1 skills: Explicit and implicit meanings](#) revision notes. For model answers to these questions, please see [Question 1 Comprehension: Model answers](#).



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Question 1 Skills: Explicit and Implicit Meanings

Question 1 Skills: Explicit and Implicit Meanings

Question 1: Comprehension on Paper 1 of your IGCSE tests you on your ability to understand the more obvious meanings in a text, as well as your ability to use clues and hints in a text to explore the more hidden meanings. You also need to be able to select and use information from the text for specific purposes.

The sections below will explain the difference between explicit and implicit meanings and how to recognise them.

Explicit versus implicit meanings

Explicit information is clear and directly expressed. Implicit refers to something that is understood, but not described or stated clearly or directly. Something stated implicitly uses **implication**, **assumption** and **inference** to generate meaning.

For example:

The long corridor was cold and windswept, making my candle flicker and the shadows quake and shudder.

- The **explicit** information in this sentence is that the corridor is long, cold and windswept
- The **implicit** meaning in this sentence is that the corridor is creepy and frightening
- This is shown by the use of imagery, such as “candle flicker” and “shadows quake and shudder”

Something that is implicit is inferred; this means you need to make a logical inference based on the evidence you are presented with. In the above example, the fact that the corridor seems to be a frightening place is a logical inference to make, based on the fact that even the shadows “quake and shudder”.

Analysing explicit and implicit meanings

When identifying and analysing the explicit and implicit meanings in a text, it is important that you explain your ideas clearly, based on the context of the text.

This means that you should:

- Develop your ideas and analysis based on the information you have been given in the text (rather than jumping to illogical conclusions):
 - For example, in the sentence “The man stumbled into the house, tripping and cursing his way up the stairs,” a logical inference would be that the man is drunk



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- This is because of the writer's use of the words "stumbled", "tripping" and "cursing"
- Jumping too far would be to suggest that the man is an alcoholic; there is no evidence in this sentence to support this
- Zoom in on particular words that support the inference you are making
- Explain why the writer may have chosen those particular words to use

For example, consider the following text:

*Only a handful have ever been found before. But none like her. Her name is Lyuba. A one-month old baby mammoth, she walked the **tundra** about 40,000 years ago, then died mysteriously. Discovered on a riverbank in Siberia, she's the most perfectly preserved woolly mammoth ever discovered. Lyuba has mesmerised the scientific world with her arrival - creating headlines across the globe.*

The explicit information in this text is:

- Lyuba is a one-month old baby mammoth who lived about 40,000 years ago
- Scientists do not know how she died
- She was discovered on a riverbank in Siberia
- She is the most perfectly preserved woolly mammoth ever discovered

What is implied in the text is:

- This is an amazing, unusual and rare scientific discovery ("Only a handful have ever been found before"/"none like her"/"most perfectly preserved woolly mammoth ever discovered")
- Scientists around the world are astounded and excited by her discovery ("Lyuba has mesmerised the scientific world")
- Her discovery is big news ("creating headlines across the globe")

What's most important is that you have evidence for all of your implied meanings (as in each of the examples above).

Critical Reading Tools

Think of critical reading as a bit like an autopsy: you have a piece of text laid out in front of you and you need to dissect it. To do that, you need to learn **what** tools there are, **how** to use them, and **when** to select the right one. These reading tools are going to help you to better interrogate the texts you're given in the exam. The 4 tools are:

Question

Clarify

Evidence

Infer



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Question 1 Comprehension: Model Answers

Question 1 Comprehension: Model Answers

Question 1 is split into two tasks: a comprehension task and a summary task. The comprehension task will be based on Text A in your reading insert, and is designed as a series of short-answer questions, testing your ability to select and interpret what you read appropriately.

Text A

The following is Text A taken from the June 2022 exam paper and is about **endurance** running events. Question 1(a-e) will ask you either to identify specific information from this text, or explain something from the text in your own words.

Text A: Endurance events

I'm not sure when endurance events like triathlons, adventure races and ultra-marathon running races (through jungle, desert and mountainous terrains) started to become popular, but they are here to stay and continue to challenge the limits of every competitor.

Not so long ago, a marathon runner was a mythical beast – we all knew someone who knew someone who had run a 42 km marathon, but most of us had only actually seen them on TV. Now everyone knows a marathon runner and they just look like normal people.

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Somewhere along the way, marathons became commonplace and a whole new breed of extreme activities arrived: the Ironman triathlon, crazy ultra-marathons and adventure races that defy description, like the Tough Mudder. While a lot of extreme challenges are to do with ultra-endurance, the Tough Mudder is short but involves getting hurt. Sometimes by electric shocks. And fire. Why would you?

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I've no idea what has made extreme sports such a phenomenon, but I do know what happened for me. After many years of corporate life and habitual laziness I found myself with a large belly, unable to get to the buffet without puffing. Horrified, I signed up immediately for a 10 km run, then a marathon. And then an Ironman. It becomes a rapidly escalating obsession. What seemed like a hardcore event reserved solely for proper endurance fanatics soon becomes just within reach.

15

My personal theory for the rise of extreme sports is that life has become sterile. The chances of getting an adrenaline rush in the average workplace are minimal, so, tired of the rat-race, people search out ways to re-engage with life.

20

After completing two Ironman events, I can testify that the feeling of sweeping down the finish chute after 226 km to pumping pop music, flashing lights and a cheering crowd is the ultimate buzz. But to the true athlete, finishing a classic marathon, quietly in an empty car park, in pouring rain, is easily its equal for an overwhelming inner sense of achievement.

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Question 1(a-e) model answers

Below you will find the questions based on the above text, along with suggested answers:

The clue in the question is "endurance events", so the answers are: triathlons and adventure races

I'm not sure when endurance events like triathlons, adventure races and ultra-marathon running races (through jungle, desert and mountainous terrains) started to become popular, but they are here to stay and continue to challenge the limits of every competitor.

1(a): Give two examples of types of endurance events, **other than ultra-marathons**

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I'm not sure when endurance events like triathlons, adventure races and ultra-marathon running races (through jungle, desert and mountainous terrains) started to become popular, but they are here to stay and continue to challenge the limits of every competitor.

This phrase has been used in the context of what competitors have to do in these events, so here it means **to push yourself beyond what you think is possible**

1(b)(i): **Using your own words**, explain what the text means by: "challenge the limits"

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This phrase has been used in the context of something that does not seem real, so here it means **an imaginary or fictitious creature**

Not so long ago, a marathon runner was a mythical beast - we all knew someone who knew someone who had run a 42 km marathon, but most of us had only actually seen them on TV. Now everyone knows a marathon runner and they just look like normal people.

1(b)(ii): Using your own words, explain what the text means by: "mythical beast"

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Somewhere along the way, marathons became commonplace and a whole new breed of extreme activities arrived: the Ironman triathlon, crazy ultra-marathons and adventure races that defy description, like the Tough Mudder. While a lot of extreme challenges are to do with ultra-endurance, the Tough Mudder is short but involves getting hurt. Sometimes by electric shocks. And fire. Why would you?

1(c): Identify **two** ways in which Tough Mudder always differs from other extreme events

Tough Mudder is short and involves getting hurt

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The clue in the question is "habitual laziness", so the answers are that the writer found himself with a large belly and he got out of breath easily

I've no idea what has made extreme sports such a phenomenon, but I do know what happened for me. After many years of corporate life and habitual laziness I found myself with a large belly, unable to get to the buffet without puffing. Horrified, I signed up immediately for a 10 km run, then a marathon. And then an Ironman. It becomes a rapidly escalating obsession. What seemed like a hardcore event reserved solely for proper endurance fanatics soon becomes just within reach.

My personal theory for the rise of extreme sports is that life has become sterile. The chances of getting an adrenaline rush in the average workplace are minimal, so, tired of the rat-race, people search out ways to re-engage with life.

1(d)(i): Give **two** reasons why the writer decided to drop their "habitual laziness" and take up running

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I've no idea what has made extreme sports such a phenomenon, but I do know what happened for me. After many years of corporate life and habitual laziness I found myself with a large belly, unable to get to the buffet without puffing. Horrified, I signed up immediately for a 10 km run, then a marathon. And then an Ironman. It becomes a rapidly escalating obsession. What seemed like a hardcore event reserved solely for proper endurance fanatics soon becomes just within reach.

My personal theory for the rise of extreme sports is that life has become sterile. The chances of getting an adrenaline rush in the average workplace are minimal, so, tired of the rat-race, people search out ways to re-engage with life.

1(d)(ii): **Explain why** extreme sports are growing in popularity

This is a 3-mark question, so you need to give three reasons in your answer:

- 1.) Life has become sterile
- 2.) People are tired of the rat-race
- 3.) People are looking for ways to re-engage with life

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After completing two Ironman events, I can testify that the feeling of sweeping down the finish chute after 226 km to pumping pop music, flashing lights and a cheering crowd is the ultimate buzz. But to the true athlete, finishing a classic marathon, quietly in an empty car park, in pouring rain, is easily its equal for an overwhelming inner sense of achievement.

1(e): **Using your own words**, explain why some Ironman competitors might still like to compete in marathons

You need to use inference in your answer and make three separate points for 3 marks:

- 1.) Classic marathons are a true sporting challenge for real athletes
- 2.) They are quieter and less flashy
- 3.) They give the same sense of achievement

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Summary

- Remember to read each sub-question carefully and highlight:
 - What you have to do (“give two examples”/“write your answer in your own words”, etc.)
 - What you have to look for in the text (the focus of the question)
- Pay attention to the number of marks awarded for each sub-question and write your answers accordingly
- Make sure you are reading the correct section of text (according to the sub-question instructions)
- If the question asks you to use your own words, *most* of your answer needs to be in your own words; you must not just copy and paste from the text
- These are short-answer questions so do not waste time writing paragraphs when short sentences will do:
 - Writing more will not get you more marks - the examiner can only award the amount of marks allocated to each sub-question

The full June 2022 exam paper is available [here](#).